

AFTER LEFT FIELD POST

Slugging Tiger Rookie Has Local 'Flavor'

REGISTER-STAR-NEWS 33
Sandusky, O., Thurs., March 15, 1956

AN "adopted" Sandusky is using a smoking bat to make a name for himself in spring training at Orlando, Florida, with Detroit's American League club. He's Ben Downs, a 6-3, 200-pound outfielder.

Downs was married here Oct. 2, 1954 at Presbyterian Church to Grace Harris, eldest daughter of Mr. and Mrs. Gerold Harris. A New Departure engineer, Harris moved here two years ago with his family from Troy, Ohio. They reside at 220 E. Monroe-st.

THE TIGERS picked him up in the draft meeting last winter after he hit .340 for Nashville in the Southern Association.

Born and raised in Detroit, he wanted to play baseball and hitch-hiked to Florida in 1947 and enrolled in a baseball school conducted by George (Snuffy) Stirnweis, of the Yankees.

The Braves signed him and he started a career which has bounced him around the minors until it finally landed him right back with the club he always wanted to play with in the first place, his hometown team.

HE IS A good hitter. Listen to these figures. His peak year was 1952 at Fresno, Cal., when he hit .342, belted 38 home runs and drove in 160 runs. His .340 at Nashville included 12 homers, 43 doubles and 108 RBIs.

There are other ones and they are impressive. He hit

.302 for Aberdeen in 1948, batted .335 with 24 home runs in 85 games at Oleon, N. Y., in 1949.

Downs considers his biggest kick out of baseball an event that happened last December.

"I was playing with a team in the Venezuelan League . . . winter ball . . . getting \$1,000 a month and expenses. Hitting good too. I finished fourth in the league with a .325."

"But on Dec. 3, a fellow on our team told me he'd seen my name in one of the local papers. It was printed in Spanish, and all he saw was Benny Downs and a lot of stuff he couldn't read."

"I got another player who knew Spanish to read it for me and he told me the Tigers had drafted me. I was the happiest guy in the world, I'll tell you . . ."

During his time in Venezuela,

To Erect Statue Honoring Connie

PHILADELPHIA, March 15 (UP)—A memorial statue of Connie Mack, waving a scorecard in front of the dugout—will be erected in Reayburn Park, a small square across the street from Connie Mack Stadium. A sculptor already has been commissioned to create the statue. Funds will be raised by a public solicitation of baseball fans throughout the country.

the couple lived in Valencia. They flew from Panama City, Panama, directly to Sandusky. He left here Feb. 18 for Orlando.

BUT LIFE hasn't always been so kind to him. Like the time the Braves signed him as a rookie back in 1948.



BEN DOWNS
... swinging loaded bat

"They gave me a conditional bonus-contract," Ben explains. "They sent me to Eau Claire, Wis. to play and told me that if they kept me until June 1, I would get a \$5,000 bonus."

"I DON'T DO so good up there. It's getting close to June 1 and I'm hoping they keep me. On May 31, we're playing Aberdeen a night game."

"It's a slow one and getting late. I come up in the eighth and hit a two-run homer to tie the game and we go into extra innings."

"It's the 12th inning and I'm due to hit when Manager Andy Cohen calls me over and says he has to take me out. I ask him why and he shows me his watch. It's two minutes to midnight."

"Got a wire today from the

Santee Resumes Fight With AAU

NEW YORK, March 15 (UP)—A formal hearing on the Wes Santee case, which will see witnesses testifying under oath, was scheduled to begin today in State Supreme Court.

Santee's attorney was to present arguments for extension of the present temporary injunction issued by court against the AAU preventing that group from enforcing its "lifetime" ban on Santee for accepting too much expense money for competing in track meets.

Santee was frankly hopeful that today's hearing would make it possible for him to compete in the Knights of Columbus

Braves," he tells me. "They decided not to keep you. If I let you play one more inning it'll be June 1 . . . you'll get the \$5,000 bonus and I'll get fired . . ."

"How about that," Benny grinned. "I miss five grand by two minutes. But that's the way it goes."

Dayton Accepts Sugar Bowl Bid

NEW ORLEANS, March 15 (UP)—The Dayton Flyers became the third team to accept an invitation to the 1956 Sugar Bowl basketball tournament here, Chairman Claude Simons announced today.

Kentucky and St. Louis also have accepted invitations. The tourney is scheduled Dec. 28-29. A fourth team to be named.

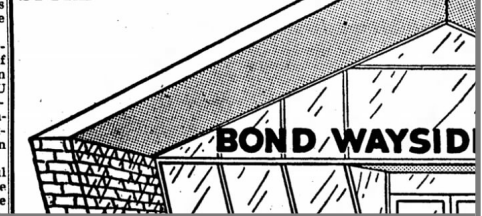
"All I'm hoping now is that I can look good enough that the Tigers will give me a shot at the left field job down there. I really feel I can hit for them."

HE'S GETTING the chance, with Jim Delsing and Charley Maxwell the guys he must beat out, mainly.

Downs, who had two for two in Sandusky's Grapefruit League opener for the Tigers against Washington, belted a homer and single to drive in two Tiger runs Sunday as they edged the Nats, 5-4.

Downs hit his home run, a 350-foot job, off Hal Griggs to start the fifth inning, and in the sixth the husky gardner looped a single to drive in the winning run. That made it four straight hits in two days before the Nats finally retired him.

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